

Setting up Claude

A no-nonsense start. Ten minutes, not a course.

1. Create your account

Go to claude.ai and sign up, email or a Google/Apple account both work. No credit card needed, the free plan gives you real, genuine use, not a crippled trial. Verify your email and you're straight into a chat.

2. Turn off training on your conversations

Do this before you type anything real into it. Click your profile icon (top right) then Settings, then Privacy. There's a toggle for letting Anthropic use your conversations to improve its models, turn it off if you'd rather your own stuff wasn't read for that. Takes ten seconds, easy to forget once you're actually using the thing.

3. Set up your first Project

This is the one setting that actually changes how useful Claude is day to day. Left sidebar, Projects, Create project. Give it a name related to what you're actually using it for, not "Project 1". In the project instructions box, tell it who you are and how you want it to talk to you: "I'm a [your job], I prefer short answers with the key point first, not three paragraphs of preamble." Upload two or three relevant documents if you have them, a CV, a brief, whatever. Now every chat inside that project starts already knowing your context instead of cold.

4. Turn on memory and set your writing style

Settings, then Capabilities, turn memory on. Settings, then Styles, pick a default tone if the standard one doesn't feel like you. Small thing, makes every answer after this feel less generic.

5. One thing to actually try today

Open your new project and ask it something real, not a test question. "Help me [thing you actually need done this week]." That's it, that's the whole point.
